

S02-02 - Eyes in the Brush

Player text

The road feels watched. A branch snaps where no wind moved it. The hybrid animals have gone quiet: lark-moths, fox-bats, all of them holding their breath the way you are holding yours. Something is keeping pace with you in the brush, and it is not an animal.

Public objective

Notice the threat before it reaches you.

Raw source

- Id: S02-02
- Type: scene
- Sectionid: ACT-TWO
- Sectiontitle: Act Two: Cargo Reclaimers
- Title: Eyes in the Brush
- Shorttitle: Eyes in the Brush
- Order: 302
- Playersafe: True
- Completioneligible: True
- Image: assets/scenes/S02-02-eyes-in-the-brush.png
- Alt: Eyes in the Brush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers.
- Caption: Eyes in the brush turn investigation into an impending tactical decision.
- Mood: Cargo Reclaimers
- Gmgoal: Run the ambush spot check and fold in the strixwolf carryover before the road breaks open.
- Publicobjective: Notice the threat before it reaches you.
- Readaloud: The road feels watched. A branch snaps where no wind moved it. The hybrid animals have gone quiet: lark-moths, fox-bats, all of them holding their breath the way you are holding yours. Something is keeping pace with you in the brush, and it is not an animal.
- Gmnotes: This is dread into snap: quiet, tell, roll, ambush. Mercy carryover is a mechanical reward, but the exact canon weight remains a Kyle confirmation flag.
- Gmscript: Say: "The forest has gone quiet in a way your bodies understand before your minds do. Make an Instinct roll against Difficulty 14. Beat it and you see them before they move. Miss it and they get the jump." If the strixwolf was calmed or helped, add: "A distant hoot gives you one heartbeat of warning. Take an advantage die." If the strixwolf was killed or left blood-debt behind, add: "The forest gives no warning this time."
- Gmreadaloud: The road feels watched. A branch snaps where no wind moved it. Something is keeping pace with you in the brush, and it is not an animal.
- Gmchecklist: Read strixwolf_outcome, strixwolf_trust, and strixwolf_blood_debt. Run Instinct 14. Set ambushAwareness to see-them-coming or ambushed. Move directly to MAP-S02-03 / S02-03 after the result.
- Gmprivate: The watchers are nervous and organized, not monsters. A high roll can

reveal salvaged corporate gear without naming the deeper truth.

- Playertakeaway: Your attention right now decides whether the encounter starts on your terms or theirs.
- Storytakeaway: The hunters are close enough to act; the road has become a trap with a heartbeat of warning.
- Mechanictakeaway: This is an Instinct 14 reaction/spot check; strixwolf mercy can grant an advantage die or lower pressure.
- Rollcards: s02-02-spot-watchers-before-the-ambush S02-02 Spot watchers before the ambush Spot watchers before the ambush Instinct Finesse Instinct Finesse 14 Instinct senses eyes; Finesse moves without giving away the scan. The party may start the ambush surrounded. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The party may start the ambush surrounded. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it costs time...
- Entityids: bramble-union bramble-union-ambusher bramble-union-claimrunner disposition-resolution-track varian-soto strixwolf-mother escort-carriage garrick-reed short-rest hidden sealed-keystone-crate strixwolf lemur-toads
- Entities: bramble-union Bramble Union faction Faction / Community assets/icons/faction.png assets/logos/bramble-union.png BRAM-bul YOO-nyun Thornscrap armor, hungry eyes, and old worker gear make the Bramble Union look dangerous before they look human. Loose label for freeholders and cargo reclaimers Called thieves by Goldspire; actually a mix of displaced workers, freeholders, and dangerous reclaimers.; show internal disagreement, practical needs, and how the faction explains itself when outsiders listen. Protect its stake in Bramble Union Ambusher, Bramble Union Claimrunner, Goldspire Territories while being seen as more than a symbol or obstacle. Called thieves by Goldspire; actually a mix of displaced workers, freeholders, and dangerous reclaimers. bramble-union-ambusher Bramble Union Ambusher enemy Enemy / Combatant assets/icons/enemy.png assets/npc-images/bramble-union-ambusher/portrait_base.png BRAM-bul YOO-nyun AM-boosh-er a road reclainer who has never done this before, and it shows The frightened body in the bushes who makes the ambush real. Bramble Union Ambusher a desperate road reclainer trying to stop the carriage without looking scared All borrowed bravado stretched thin...
- Factionids: bramble-union
- Clueids: bramble-claim-marker bramble-are-criminals-noticetm
- Worldconnectionprompts: S02-02-bramble-union-world-connection bramble-union The Bramble Union You have been desperate enough to do something you are not proud of. What was it, and would you do it again to eat?
- Statecontrols: strixwolf_outcome Strixwolf outcome select unresolved calmed helped avoided attacked killed Calmed/helped can grant advantage; killed/blood debt removes warning or increases pressure. strixwolf_trust Strixwolf trust number 3 Trust 1+ can

justify the warning beat. strixwolf_blood_debt Strixwolf blood debt checkbox If checked, do not grant mercy warning. ambushAwareness Ambush awareness select unresolved see-them-coming ambushed Sets who acts first in S02-03. closingInCountdown Closing In countdown number 4 If high, begin with worse position or fewer clean sightlines.

- Mechanics: action-roll instinct finesse hidden restrained adversary-spotlight reaction-rolls advantage-disadvantage countdown hope fear
- Playerquestions: What detail in Eyes in the Brush tells you the official story is incomplete? Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it? What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?
- Relationshipprompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownershipprompt: Name one detail in Eyes in the Brush that belongs to your character's point of view.
- Fearsponds: Spend Fear to close the ambush net, threaten the Keystone route, or force a choice between cargo and mercy. Close the ambush net or put a PC between cargo and a frightened reclaimer. Reveal a personal effect that makes victory emotionally complicated.
- Choicesconsequences: Spot them first PCs act first or can call out before blades move. S02-03 parley starts easier because the party is not reacting from panic. If missed, the ambushers begin closer to the carriage. Call out to the brush Creates a tense social opening. S02-03 de-escalation can start before the first injury. If the call sounds like a threat, the fight opens sharper. Use strixwolf mercy payoff Advantage die or softer ambush pressure. S02-04 can echo that mercy changes how people judge the party. Blood debt removes the warning and hardens the scene tone.
- Lootclues: Signal knot Hidden boot track
- Handoutids: Signal knots
- Sourcescenelug: S02-02-eyes-in-the-brush
- Sourcefiles: dist/Act2_Upgrade_Packet/ACT2_SCENE_UPGRADES.md
dist/Act2_Upgrade_Packet/ACT2_PER_CHARACTER.md
- References: Act 1 mercy carryover #S01-04 Ambush map #MAP-S02-03 Ambush scene #S02-03
- Storyscope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. The reclaimers target the cargo and manifest, not purses, and avoid killing when possible. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Their gear includes salvaged, repainted Grail/Kazrak kit: ex-workers, not feral bandits. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Knowledge Medium 15 to name the issue "That stone belongs in the ground." "You do not know what you are carrying." ADD EARNED A spared/captured reclaimer says monster attacks spiked when protection contracts went on sale. ADD EARNED Presence Medium 15; requires mercy or capture Instinct: spot ambush. Presence: parley/interrogate. Knowledge: recognize corporate-issue gear. ACT2 Act 2: Bramble ambush 90 0:55 to 1:30 1:30 first combat and possible interrogation Abstract the fight via a Group Action roll; keep one captured reclaimer for the interrogation seed.
- Livetools: encounter S02-02 MAP-S02-03 pages/combat/s02-03.html
- Percharacterlayer: varian-soto Varian Soto Heightened senses The silenced animals

scream threat to a forest-raised Katari before anyone else has proof. Instinct 14 Can lead the spot check and smell the ambushers' position before seeing them. Can silently mark positions for allies, turning panic into a ready posture. Varian, the quiet is wrong and you know it first. Want to lead the Instinct 14 spot check? barnacle Barnacle Counter-ambush Feels the setup because he knows what an ambush wants from the victim. Instinct 13 Spots the flanking pattern and the leader's likely position. Can pre-position in cover or ready a non-lethal opener. Barnacle, you set traps like this. Want to spot theirs and turn it around? khari-nix Khari Nix First shield Already decides who she will shield if the brush moves first. Can interpose before the first blow lands, softening an Ambushed result for one ally. Khari, if they jump you, you can take the first hit meant for someone else. Ready for that? garrick-reed Garrick Reed Reluctant movement Reads hesitation in the watchers' movement; these are not practiced killers. Can call out with warmth instead of threat, making S02-03 parley easier. Garrick, whoever is out there...

- Takeawayhelp: Player takeaway Your attention right now decides whether the encounter starts on your terms or theirs. "Eyes up. What you notice in the next ten seconds decides whether you start ready or reeling." "You can scan the treeline, quietly warn the others, ready the carriage defense, or call out to whoever is there. The roll tells us how much time you have." Offer concrete pre-roll posture: scan, warn, ready, call out, shield the package, or move the carriage line. instinct reaction-rolls advantage-disadvantage Story takeaway The hunters are close enough to act; the road has become a trap with a heartbeat of warning. "They are in the brush right now. The only question is whether you see them before they move." "You see low figures, deliberate movement, and a flanking pattern. You do not have names yet." Describe shapes and tactics before names. The story beat is proximity and pressure, not faction lore. instinct reaction-rolls advantage-disadvantage Mechanic takeaway This is an Instinct 14 reaction/spot check; strixwolf mercy can grant an advantage die or lower pressure. "Roll Instinct against 14. If the forest warned you because of mercy earlier, take an advantage die." "Success means...
- Playerbeats: S02-02-quiet The quiet The quiet is wrong assets/scenes/S02-02-eyes-in-the-brush.png Eyes in the Brush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. The small forest sounds stop. The road feels watched before anyone sees a face. The small forest sounds stop. The road feels watched before anyone sees a face. The small forest sounds stop. The road feels watched before anyone sees a face. text-first S02-02-tell The tell A branch snaps assets/scenes/S02-02-eyes-in-the-brush.png Eyes in the Brush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. A branch snaps without wind. Low figures move deliberately through the brush, flanking the road. A branch snaps without wind. Low figures move deliberately through the brush, flanking the road. A branch snaps without wind. Low figures move deliberately through the brush, flanking the road. text-first S02-02-spot-check Spot check Instinct 14 assets/scenes/S02-02-eyes-in-the-brush.png Eyes in the Brush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. Roll Instinct against Difficulty 14. See them first, or get caught flat-footed. Roll Instinct against Difficulty 14. See them first, or get caught flat-footed. Roll Instinct against Difficulty 14. See them first, or get caught flat-footed...
- Gmbeats: S02-02-quiet The quiet The quiet is wrong Say: "The animals go quiet all at once. Who notices first, and what gives it away?" The small forest sounds stop. The road feels watched before anyone sees a face. The living forest becomes a signal

system. Passive perception can become spotlight before the roll. Players know the environment is warning them. Player takeaway Players know the environment is warning them. "The animals go quiet all at once. Who notices first, and what gives it away?" "The playable facts are: The small forest sounds stop. The road feels watched before anyone sees a face." Use this beat to point the table at one immediate choice. The player-facing fact is: The small forest sounds stop. The road feels watched before anyone sees a face. instinct table-spotlight Story takeaway The living forest becomes a signal system. "The animals go quiet all at once. Who notices first, and what gives it away?" "The story fact you can trust is: The living forest becomes a signal system." This beat changes the fiction through this exact pressure: The living forest becomes a signal system. instinct table-spotlight Mechanic takeaway Passive perception can become spotlight before...

- Beatautoplayeligible: True
- Beatautoplaydefault: False
- Beatautoplayintervalms: 7000
- Playersafeprojection: S02-02 scene Eyes in the Brush assets/scenes/S02-02-eyes-in-the-brush.png Eyes in the Brush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. Eyes in the brush turn investigation into an impending tactical decision. Cargo Reclaimers Notice the threat before it reaches you. The road feels watched. A branch snaps where no wind moved it. The hybrid animals have gone quiet: lark-moths, fox-bats, all of them holding their breath the way you are holding yours. Something is keeping pace with you in the brush, and it is not an animal. S02-02-quiet The quiet The quiet is wrong assets/scenes/S02-02-eyes-in-the-brush.png Eyes in the Brush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. The small forest sounds stop. The road feels watched before anyone sees a face. The small forest sounds stop. The road feels watched before anyone sees a face. The small forest sounds stop. The road feels watched before anyone sees a face. text-first S02-02-tell The tell A branch snaps assets/scenes/S02-02-eyes-in-the-brush.png Eyes in the Brush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. A branch snaps without wind. Low figures move deliberately through the brush, flanking the road. A branch snaps without wind. Low figures move deliberately through the...
- Companionmapids: MAP-S02-03
- Slidenumber: 33
- Totalslides: 110
- Spotlights: SPOT-M-GROUP group-action-roll group-action-roll M9 S02-02 med mandatory first-use-group-roll Do It as a Team One lead, one shared resolution. One PC leads the action. Everyone else makes a reaction roll. Add +1 for each helper success and -1 for each helper failure. Group Action wiki/mechanic/group-action-roll teach-by-example Prevent group checks from becoming five unrelated solo rolls. mechanic defer-if-clock-critical True True
- Spotlightsummary: 1

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